

Richmond, over what to do. On his way to rejoin General Robert E. Lee at Fredericksburg, General James Longstreet proposed to President Davis that he and two divisions travel by rail to Tennessee to assault Major General William Rosecrans. Longstreet would thereby relieve pressure on Vicksburg. Secretary of War James Seddon then countered with a wild proposal to send Longstreet directly to Mississippi to attack General Ulysses S. Grant's rear at Vicksburg, but Lee stepped in at this point, arguing convincingly for another thrust north. Lee proposed that now was the time to deal the Union a strategic death blow before conditions in the West deteriorated to a point of no return. He was also keen to advance while both the Northern peace movement and the Army of Northern Virginia were still strong.